

EG Update

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【メール原文】

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Dear Satoshi,

Marc Gustafson here, filling in for Ian during his annual August sabbatical on Nantucket. For those I haven't met, I joined Eurasia Group last year after serving as the White House chief of intelligence and head of the Situation Room. In those roles and earlier ones across the intelligence community, I spent a lot of time focused on Iran, planning for a large-scale conflict, coordinating with US counterparts in the Gulf and Israel, and watching the proxy conflict play out.

Which is why the question I get most often in client briefings is some version of the same one: how did the US get Iran so wrong? Was it a strategic miscalculation, a failure of impulse control, or has the campaign been the success the administration claims?

With that in mind, I am devoting this week's update to what I think happened and what it means for the years ahead.

How the US miscalculated in Iran

Killing the Supreme Leader and launching a sustained bombing campaign were supposed to break the regime. Six months later, hardliners are in charge, the new supreme leader is more hawkish than his father was, Iran is in partial control of the Strait of Hormuz, and US bases across the Gulf have been hit again and again.

In every administration I worked for at the White House (Obama, Biden, Trump), I watched presidents navigate major foreign policy blunders, usually stemming from a mix of leadership style, judgment errors, and sometimes overconfidence in American military power. Syria, Libya, and Afghanistan all belong on that list.

There is an old line in Washington, "There are only policy successes and intelligence failures." It is half a joke and half an accurate description of how blame is distributed. So, who is to blame for what happened in Iran? Because I take pride in being apolitical as a former intelligence official, I am going to leave the politics alone and focus on where the analysis went wrong, including, in some cases, my own.

1. Some in Washington believed they had help on the inside

About a month before the strikes, rumors were rife in Washington that the US was quietly searching for its Iranian version of Delcy Rodríguez, the Venezuelan vice president who pledged to work with Washington after Maduro was gone.

As best I can tell, the US had three channels open to Iranians.

The first was a set of contacts with senior officials, run by CIA. Trump referred to this repeatedly after the attack, even suggesting one of the contacts had been accidentally killed in the strike. Given the

seniority of those who were killed in the strike, I can see how the White House may have seen this channel as a promising opportunity.

The second was a deportation line through ICE and the FBI. Court filings from July show a flurry of ICE and FBI communication with senior Iranian officials in Washington about deportation flights in the months before the war, with more than 100 Iranians returned between September 2025 and January 2026. The litigation is about whether asylum seekers' information was shared illegally, but what caught my eye was the timing. Why did ICE/FBI communication with Iranian officials pick up so sharply in the weeks before the strikes? And why was the Trump administration sending asylum seekers back to Iran shortly before and after the government was gunning down protesters in the street? I cannot substantiate that the channel was repurposed. I can say that in my experience, channels like that tend to be.

The third was a channel run by the Mossad that involved a regime-collapse plan. The Mossad built it around Iranian Kurdish groups in northern Iraq and former president Mahmoud Ahmadinejad. Then Mossad chief David Barnea told Netanyahu and senior US officials that he could foment an uprising that would collapse the government in a matter of days, pairing a Kurdish ground advance with Israeli and American air cover. Ahmadinejad was to take charge afterward. Israeli officials involved referred to him as "the friend."

Shortly after the US struck Tehran and the plan had been activated, President Trump called it off, following an 11th-hour plea from President Erdogan. By then, Mossad operatives had already struck the perimeter of Ahmadinejad's heavily guarded residence with one-way attack drones to free him. They moved him to a safe house, and he walked away soon after having lost faith in the effort. The Kurdish militia leaders received mixed messages and then saw news reports indicating they were marching into Iran, despite never having mobilized. According to Israeli journalists and leaks from Israeli intelligence officials, many of them were sipping coffee when word of the supposed Kurdish march came in over the radio. Gadi Eisenkot has since called the plan "insane," and the new Mossad chief has removed two senior officials associated with it.

Add it up and you get a rag-tag Kurdish militia that took weapons and never crossed the border, a former Iranian official best known for two decades of anti-American rants and Holocaust denial, and a set of contacts of uncertain value. As one US official told me before the attack on Tehran, "we've got a lot of irons in the fire, and we're watching to see which ones get hot."

Individually, none of these channels was worth much. In aggregate, the theory that something would emerge from them at the moment of truth proved alluring in both Washington and Tel Aviv. But the plan depended on a question the intelligence community has never answered: how large is the anti-regime share of the Iranian population? Nobody knew, and the National Intelligence Council said as much in February, shortly before the attack, assessing that neither limited strikes nor a long campaign was likely to produce a movement capable of taking power.

2. The White House underestimated Iran's willingness to attack the Gulf

If the first failure was believing Iranians would come to us, the second was believing Iran would not turn on its neighbors.

Several Gulf states are Iran's trading partners and quickly growing military powers. Pulling them into a war against you, with the largest US naval concentration in years already arrayed at your doorstep, looked like a death wish. That was my read at the time, as it was for many at the White House, but it

was wrong.

The historical record supported it. Iran had been careful to communicate quietly with the Gulf states during earlier US and Israeli attacks, including after the killing of Soleimani, the bombing of Fordow, and the Israeli campaign against Iran's missile program two years ago. In each case, Tehran privately signaled that it did not intend to attack them. What we treated as a standing feature of Iranian strategy was, in retrospect, a feature of Khamenei's Iran specifically.

To be fair to my former colleagues, the community did warn. Reuters has reported that Trump was briefed before the war that striking Iran could trigger retaliation against Gulf capitals. UK Defense Intelligence and MI6, among America's closest partners on this file, war-gamed it and went further, calling an attack "highly probable" if Iran felt cornered. And on 1 February, immediately before the strikes, the supreme leader said publicly that he would start a regional war if attacked, while Iran rushed out oil shipments and drew down storage in ways that pointed clearly toward closing the strait.

So the possibility was on the table. What the US analysis lacked was conviction. The community's formulation was that Iran "could" widen retaliation to American allies, and one source described it as sitting on a list of potential outcomes rather than as a likely one. Hundreds of missiles and thousands of drones against six Gulf states plus Jordan fell outside what most of us thought Tehran would risk. Writing that Iran "could" do something is technically defensible and very easy for a decisionmaker to wave off. It is also worth saying plainly that the scenarios were drafted against a more limited campaign than the one that was launched. Eliminating more than 40 of Iran's most senior leaders in a single morning, and following that with large-scale attacks on almost all of Iran's military sites, was an attack at a scale no analytic product had modeled, and it made Gulf-wide retaliation far more predictable than the assessments implied.

3. US military planners were too confident they could entomb Iran's missiles and drones

This was the biggest analytic failure of the campaign in my view. The plan was to hit the entrances and egress routes at Iran's underground missile and drone sites, trap the weapons inside, and then have US firepower dominance. US and Israeli strikes hit 69 tunnel entrances across 18 underground facilities in a matter of days, collapsed most of them, and cratered the access roads so launchers could not get out.

Then Iran brought in front-end loaders and dump trucks. By late May, commercial satellite imagery showed Iran had reopened 50 of the 69 entrances, filled in nearly all the road craters, and repaved two sites. The missiles themselves sat under 400 to 700 feet of granite and came through largely untouched. This means that some of these storage facilities are hundreds of feet deeper than the Fordow facility, which sits roughly 260 to 300 feet underground.

These sites were built with multiple entrances, decoy openings, blast doors, and compartmented tunnels precisely so they could absorb a first wave and get back to work. Weeks of American airpower were undone with basic construction equipment and time.

Part of why many believed the strikes would be successful was because of the bombing of the Fordow nuclear site. The US effectively buried the enrichment halls in June 2025 and spent the next eight months watching Iranians slowly dig out, so US planners assumed this could be replicated with missile strikes. But enrichment needs cascades and precision components. Missile storage needs a hole in a mountain and a road out of it.

4. The US drew the wrong lessons from the 12-day war

Beyond Fordow, June 2025 taught the US three more things that turned out to be misleading.

Retaliation. Iran's response in 2025 to Israeli and US strikes was carefully calibrated, a telegraphed strike on Al Udeid, Qatar, with advance warning and no casualties, which gave both sides a way to step back. Many read that as Tehran's revealed preference for restraint. It more likely reflected a leadership that wanted off-ramps while it was still alive and in place. When you kill the Supreme Leader and 40 senior officials in one morning, the calculation changes.

Proxies. Hezbollah sat out the 12-day war and the Houthis contributed almost nothing. Many took that as evidence the Axis of Resistance was spent, and in conventional terms it was, especially after the pager attacks, the Lebanon bombing campaign, and the US and Israeli strikes against the Houthi leadership in August and September 2025. Each group proved more resilient than most expected. Hezbollah has found creative ways to sustain drone attacks into northern Israel, and the Houthis have proved wily and mobile enough to remain a genuine threat to shipping and to Gulf infrastructure.

The previous Supreme Leader. US intelligence officers who know Iran well have long observed that Khamenei was the voice of restraint inside the system, and that pattern held across my entire career watching Iranian retaliation, from US strikes in Iraq to Israel's campaigns in Lebanon to both countries' attacks on the nuclear program. In every case it was the supreme leader who counseled a cautious and proportional response. What planners failed to anticipate was that killing him would free military hardliners to act on decades of accumulated frustration over what they had always regarded as humiliatingly weak responses.

What this means going forward

The US and Israel now understand three things they did not understand in February: Iran's stockpiles are deeper and better protected than the targeting assumed; Iran will hit Gulf capitals when cornered; and replenishing American interceptor inventories will take years. I expect that will eventually translate into reluctance to launch another sustained campaign the closer we get to the 2028 election, though limited strikes remain live throughout. I would put the odds of a new US bombing campaign inside Iran in the next 12 months at roughly one in four, with two variables capable of moving that quickly: a visible dash to a nuclear weapon, or an Iranian strike that kills Americans in large numbers, by which I mean more than a couple dozen.

Iran. Tehran is moving in the opposite direction, and the recent appointments show it. Mojtaba Khamenei is in charge and has consolidated faster than I expected. Mohsen Rezaei took the Supreme National Security Council on August 9, Mohammad Zolghadr was pushed down to political adviser, and Ahmad Vahidi's appointment at the IRGC completes a hardline slate with little institutional voice for restraint left in it. Rezaei's framing is the one to watch: he has said the strait matters "more than dozens of nuclear bombs," and that Iran must tighten its control over it even if nuclear concessions are made. The strait, in other words, is the deterrent that replaced the one the US destroyed. Expect reconstitution on two tracks at different speeds. Ballistic missile inventories rebuild fastest, and I would expect Iran back near pre-war stockpile levels within 12-18 months. The nuclear program is slower and more visible, which is precisely why it is the more dangerous of the two.

China. Beijing drew two lessons that cut against each other. Trump's willingness to use force and absorb risk was noted. So was the harder lesson that subduing a smaller adversary armed with drones, asymmetric capabilities, and the will to fight is not easy. Taiwan's planners have taken that same lesson in the opposite direction. But Beijing also knows exactly which American munitions inventories are depleted and how long they take to rebuild, and that knowledge has a shelf life. The window it opens

closes as US stockpiles recover in the next few years, which argues for Chinese patience rather than Chinese adventurism. I expect China to take a deliberately hands-off posture on Iran and show a willingness to let the US absorb the costs.

Russia. The first months were good for Moscow: high oil prices, de facto sanctions relief on Russian crude, resumed Indian oil purchases, and a genuine international distraction from Ukraine. But I would caution Putin to be careful what he wishes for. The oil windfall is the most fragile line on the ledger. Once a Hormuz accommodation returns Iranian barrels to a market that also has Venezuelan supply climbing and OPEC+ spare capacity waiting, prices can fall as fast as they rose and Russia's fiscal math deteriorates quickly. And the precedent set in Tehran, that Washington will decapitate the leadership of a nuclear-threshold adversary and accept the consequences, is one that I bet is keeping him up at night.

The US. The US emerges from Iran more feared and less trusted. Washington proved it will decapitate the leadership of a nuclear-threshold state and absorb the consequences, and I doubt Moscow or Beijing has dismissed that. It is credibility of a narrow kind, though. It shows the US can impose enormous costs, but it also shows the US cannot achieve a political outcome, protect the partners who host it, or replenish what it expends.

The longer timeline. This is my most contrarian call. If the regime survives the next twelve months of economic contraction, and if President Trump and Iran decide not to escalate in the coming weeks, I expect the Middle East to be more stable after 2028 than it is today. Iran will have established that it can close the strait and absorb an American campaign, and its rebuilding missile and drone forces will make renewed US or Israeli operations harder with each month that passes. The US will be replenishing inventories at a slower rate, resting its Navy, and wanting oil and pump prices low through an election year. Israel will grow more cautious once it understands it may not have American cover even for a limited strike against Iran's reconstitution. And whoever wins in 2028 will arrive less willing to fight a Middle East war than this administration was, particularly one requiring extensive support for Israel, given how quickly anti-Israel sentiment is growing in both parties.

The Gulf states are the actors most likely to lock that outcome in. Having been struck for a war they did not want, Riyadh, Abu Dhabi, and Doha have every incentive to convert their existing quiet channels to Tehran into something more formal, and to make clear to Washington that their territory is not available for a repeat.

All the best,

Marc

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